

Corin Braga (edit.), *Enciclopedia imaginariilor din România*, First vol., Imaginar literar. Coordinated by Adrian Tudurachi. Iași, Polirom, 2020, 440 p. [The Encyclopaedia of Romanian Imaginaries, Volume I: Literary Imaginary].

It is without doubt that the first volume of *The Encyclopedia of Romanian Imaginaries*, that concerning Romanian literature, represents a much needed achievement in the research of the autochthonous share of the imagosphere. This valuable instrument finally grants an encyclopedic view of “the landforms”¹ (20) mapping Romanian literature while achieving a new literary history, reorganized according to the criterion of the semantic pool, as Corin Braga’s introductory chapter seeks to clarify.

Since to properly summarize and accordingly evaluate the content of an encyclopedia far exceeds the power and the parameters of a mere review, the perspective which interests me is a narrower one. Out of the circle or the wheel that lies in the etymology of the concept of encyclopedia, in this case, I will focus on only one spoke, and that is, given my ethnological interest, folklore.

There are no less than twenty academic articles forming the volume dedicated to the Literary Imaginary, written by just as many hardworking scholars, each of them achieving a panoramic view of the semantic pool that he/her specializes in. Out of those twenty chapters of the volume, nine of them reference folklore, either in a stationary fashion or “on the run”, while the opening chapter focuses on folklore exclusively. This proportion speaks for the importance of the ethnologic material in the Romanian literary imaginary and proves that it is an indispensable topic in any approach of understanding the autochthonous culture that claims to be exhaustive, i.e. encyclopedic. One might assert that by having its own chapter, its own chair at the table of the most significant Romanian semantic pools, ethnology is justly represented in a project that deals, after all, with written literature. That remains to be seen.

The study that inaugurates the volume is called *The Folkloric Chronotope*, written by Eleonora Sava. As it can be understood from the title, the article uses Mikhail Bakhtin’s concept of the chronotope in order to define the imaginary of Romanian folklore, which constitutes “a model of a fictional world in which the worldview configured in customary thinking via images, symbols, beliefs, themes, motifs and archetypes is revealed.”² (23). Space and time, since they are merged within any imaginary universe, model that very universe and constitute the gateway towards the semantic sphere. Bakhtin discerns between large/extensive/essential, chronotopes and small chronotopes (but there are also intermediate ones), the smaller ones usually serving as mere fractions of the first category. “The folkloric chronotope is a large chronotope”³ (23), this is the premise of Eleonora Sava’s article. The intermediate

¹ „forme de relief”. All Romanian language references have been translated by the author of the review.

² „Folclorul românesc constituie un model de lume ficțională în care se relevă viziunea asupra lumii, așa cum se configurează ea în gândirea cutumiară, prin imagini, simboluri, credințe, teme, motive, arhetipuri”.

³ „Cronotopul folcloric este un cronotop mare”.

chronotopes within the large Romanian folkloric pool will be called major chronotopes or dominant ones because they represent the main pillars of the folkloric imaginary. These dominant chronotopes serve as structural basis of Eleonora Sava's article. Thus the scholar identifies three main space-time structures that illustrate the architecture of the Romanian customary imaginary: the chronotopes of balance, those of conflict and the chronotopes of the threshold.

The chronotopes of balance are illustrated by the familial/familiar spaces. One can imagine concentric circles in order to visualize the universe in which the typical exponent of customary Romanian thinking feels safe. The smallest of these circles is represented by the house, the following, larger ones are the yard and the village. The motif of the connection between generations is the one that testifies for this worldview. The human lies at the absolute center of these, since humanity is the main requirement and the measure of order in the world of Romanian folklore, and it is the main difference between this world and "the world beyond", or "the other realm" that lacks humanity entirely. **The chronotopes of the threshold**, also called of "crisis", are represented by liminal spaces, the breaches where order, safety are interfered with. "In the Romanian folkloric texts, the intrinsic connection between space and time is evidenced by the popular concept according to which the fortunate and unfortunate powers of time are transferred unto space"⁴(27). Therefore, where space is discontinuous, sliding into unfortunate or evil time is also likely. The small chronotopes to be identified within the first circle mentioned before are: the threshold, the door, the oven, the chimney and the well. Moving to the wider circles, the dangerous liminal spaces are: the crossroads, the border, the road, the bridge, abandoned houses or churches, the mill, the deserted space and the forest. **The chronotopes of conflict** are mostly described in the fantastic fairy tale. They are represented by "the realm beyond". It serves as an obligatory stage in the hero's initiation, the place from which he/she emerges victorious and learns to rightly praise and fulfil the potential of the world back home. Some fairy tales reveal linear spatial structures, others concentric. Some configure ascending spatial structures, some descending ones. The last subchapter, **Time Series**, compensates for the privileged position that space held in the previous subchapters. It focuses on motifs like: the reversibility of time, the motifs of rebirth and rejuvenation; time dilatation; temporary suspension, petrifying; time acceleration; reversed chronology, the realm of immortality, all followed by examples from the Romanian folklore. "Asymmetrical space-time structures are built on the idea of the relativity of time, as intuited by customary thinking"⁵(45). Eleonora Sava's article is a solid introduction both into the Romanian literary imaginary and in Romanian folklore/mythology in general. It has a very clear structure and its documentation is obviously that of a specialist. Not least, it bears a fascinating atmosphere thanks both to its research material and to the perfectly chosen illustrations belonging to the visual artist Rada Niță, who so graciously and uniquely reclaims and depicts the captivating nature of Romanian folk-mythology.

⁴ În textele folclorice românești, conexiunea intrinsecă a spațiului și timpului se evidențiază prin concepția populară conform căreia puterile faste sau nefaste ale timpului se transferă asupra spațiului.

⁵ "Structurile spațio-temporale paralele și asimetrice sunt construite pe ideea relativității timpului, așa cum a fost intuită de gândirea cutumiară".

The rest of the articles mentioning folklore do so in various proportions, according to the importance it bears in the composition and history of the other semantic pools/imaginaries structuring the volume. Thus, folklore is also brought into discussion by Laura Lazăr in *The Religious Imaginary*, across multiple literary and historical periods. **The religious imaginary of Old Romanian Literature** meets ethnology when discussing Dimitrie Cantemir. The author of *Descriptio Moldaviae* explains the religiosity of the Moldavian people throughout their history, why they are sometimes prone to excesses (but not heresies) and how Christianity in these regions is interwoven with pre-Christian influences coming from the Dacian, Scythian and Greco-Roman pantheons, from the folkloric imaginary. The Moldavian humanist offers an ethno-mythological mini-dictionary in the year 1769, numbering 25 minor local deities. “In fact, Cantemir identifies some mechanisms of construction of the religious imaginary which are present, as he noted, outside the Romanian space as well”⁶ (54). The same subchapter highlights the folkloric sources that fuel the religious imaginary: stories with divine protagonists (God, Saint Peter, the Theotokos), or evil ones (the Devil with his many interesting names). Romanian fairy tales incorporate religious symbols when imagining *the realm beyond* and other parts of the journey of initiation, such as the adjuvant characters, saints named after the fortunate days of the week. Obviously, the texts accompanying rites of passage or the lyrics of carols are also impregnated by religious elements. The rest of Laura Lazăr’s article mentions folklore when discussing the religious imaginary present in the works of Ion Budai-Deleanu (an exponent of the Enlightenment), Ion Creangă, Ion Luca Caragiale (late 19th century Romanian “classics”), Ion Pillat, Nechifor Crainic and Radu Gyr (poets of the 20th century).

Lionel Roșca’s chapter, *Romanian literature of historical inspiration* also has a few things to say about folklore. “Chronologically speaking, the first intersection between history and fiction takes place, locally, in folklore”⁷ (80–81). The scholar draws attention to the fact that folk literature, despite its name, is not literature, but something else that is not in fact inspired by history but “enduring its terror” (Mircea Eliade), folklore melts history and “recrystallizes it according to the patterns of mythical thinking and collective psychology, [...] sublimating it into an impersonal and imperishable mythology, populated not by literary ‘types’ but eternal archetypes” (81)⁸.

Since Romanian folklore as a formal institution dates from the 19th century, thanks to the efforts and strategies of autochthonous Romantics, it was to be expected that the chapter dedicated to *The Imaginary of Romanian Romanticism* would include our subject. Firstly, when Romanian literature tries to encapsulate the dark side of High Romanticism, writers such as Alecsandri, Asachi, Bolintineanu freely combine Western myths and autochthonous folkloric sources. Author Ioana Bot highlights an interesting episode involving ethnology, where the most successful myth of the early Romanian Romanticism,

⁶ „În fapt, Cantemir identifica astfel unele mecanisme de construcție ale imaginarului religios, prezente, așa cum el însuși nota, la nivel general, nu doar în spațiul românesc”.

⁷ „Cronologic, prima intersecție între istorie și ficțiune se petrece, pe plan local, în cadrele folclorului”.

⁸ „o re-cristalizează potrivit tiparelor gândirii mitice și ale psihologiei colective (lucru dovedit deja în perioada interbelică, în cursul disputei P. Caraman/D. Caracostea), sublimând-o în impersonală și imperisabilă mitologie, populată nu de «tipuri» literare, ci de arhetipuri eterne”.

Asachi's ethnogenesis myth (also known as the myth of Trajan and Dochia), develops an incredible career for itself. From a *livresque* construct it enters the educational circuit, then the folkloric one, so that a century later, G. Călinescu will erroneously place it at the beginning of his enormous literary history as one of the four founding myths of Romanian culture (considering it a product of folklore). The Romanian "forty-eighters" were avid readers of Herder and Giambattista Vico. In the process of nation building, these pioneers were very eager to harvest autochthonous folklore and instrumentalize it in a political manner, in the interest of a national pantheon. "Aside from national history and the nature of the homeland, the third element of Kogălniceanu's *Introduction* were the popular traditions, meaning folklore"⁹(148) Compared to the rest of Europe, Romanian collections of folklore are delayed. The most important such collection of Romanian Romanticism belongs to Alecsandri: *Poesii poporale* [*Folk Poetry*] (1852–1853). It offers a model of how folklore should be gathered, revised and commented. "What interests us in understanding the role which folklore plays in the configuration of the Imaginary of Romanian Romanticism are not the collections themselves, but the commentary that they stirred among writers, who extracted a particular image of the Romanian village, one of a highly idealized beauty, where people work and celebrate cheerfully, in accordance with the ancestral tradition"¹⁰(148). According to Ioana Bot, for the "forty-eighters" folklore serves in fact as a treasury of arguments for Romania's national exceptionality. "Folk literature is a part of the national imaginary and it will remain the dominant perspective of Romanian culture until the end of modernity"¹¹(149).

Urban folklore also makes an appearance in the first volume of Braga's encyclopedia. Surprisingly enough, it is mentioned in the chapter dedicated to *Rural literature*, written by Cosmin Borza. While urban folklore is taken into account when discussing the novels of Marin Preda and Dan Lungu, its rural counterpart is only hinted at. Folklore is to be intuited as a dimension of the artificial idyllic peasant in his museified form, as he is depicted by a certain tradition of Romanian literature.

Other than the studies mentioned previously, folklore makes a brief appearance in the following articles of the volume: Adriana Stan's *Authenticist literature*; Levente T. Szabo's *The imaginary of the Hungarian literature in Romania*; Dana Bizulean's *German literature written in Romania* and Marius Conkan's *Alternative worlds*.

The presence of folklore in the first volume of *The Encyclopedia of Imaginaries in Romania* is a significant one, both quantitatively and qualitatively. Appearing throughout nine articles and handled professionally by competent academics, it is safe to say that folklore is well represented in the *Literary Imaginary*. The volume serves (among many other noble purposes, of course) as a testimony for the importance of ethnologic material

⁹ „Alături de istoria națională și de natura patriei, cel de-al treilea element invocat de Kogălniceanu în «Introducere» erau tradițiile populare, adică folclorul”.

¹⁰ „Dar ceea ce ne interesează, spre a înțelege rolul folclorului în configurarea imaginarului romantic românesc, nu sunt culegerile propriu-zise, ci comentariile pe care ele le-au iscat din partea scriitorilor ce au extras din multitudinea de texte o imagine particulară a satului românesc, de o frumusețe mult idealizată, unde oamenii muncesc și sărbătoresc cu veselie, respectând tradițiile strămoșești”.

¹¹ „Literatura populară participă la imaginarul național și aceasta va rămâne, în esență, perspectiva dominantă în cultura românească, până la sfârșitul modernității”.